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Credit - Drishti Ias

India's Kharif Preparedness Amid El Niño



Source: PIB

In response to a significantly delayed southwest monsoon and a **43% rainfall deficit**, the Union Ministry of Agriculture & Farmers Welfare has proactively rolled out a **multi-layered contingency framework** to safeguard the upcoming **Kharif season against potential El Niño disruptions**.

- **Vulnerability Mapping and Prioritization:** The government has identified **315 districts across 12 states** (including Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Gujarat, Uttar Pradesh, and Rajasthan) as potentially vulnerable to weak monsoon conditions.
 - Out of these, **111 high-priority districts** have been isolated due to critical **irrigation coverage falling below 25%**.
 - 76 districts are classified as medium priority (25-50% irrigation coverage), while 128 districts are low priority due to relatively better irrigation facilities.
- **Contingency Planning:** The **Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR)** has formulated **District Agriculture Contingency Plans**. These localised, district-specific blueprints are being strictly transitioned from administrative files into actionable, field-level documents.
- **Climate-Resilient Crop Diversification:** States are mandated to promote **short-duration, low-water, and drought-resistant crop varieties**. Special cultivation emphasis is being shifted toward **pulses, oilseeds, and Shree Anna (millets)** to distribute risk and maintain agricultural yield in rainfed zones.
- **Macro Water Harvesting Framework:** Repair and desiltation of community assets like check dams, farm ponds, and reservoirs are being integrated aggressively with **MGNREGA** (now **VB-GRAMG**) to simultaneously create local employment and boost water-table recharge.
- **Three-Tier Financial Safety Nets:** The financial resilience of affected farmers is being anchored through the convergence of three flagship schemes: **Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana (PMFBY)** for swift crop-loss insurance, accelerated disbursement of **Kisan Credit Cards (KCC)** for liquid working capital, and direct cash support via **PM-KISAN**.
- **Real-Time Institutional Monitoring:** To prevent data silos, a dedicated '**El Niño Monitoring Cell**' and a '**Crop Weather Watch Group**' have been institutionalized in New Delhi to coordinate weekly secretary-level and ministerial reviews alongside **731 Krishi Vigyan Kendras (KVKs)** for grassroots scientific advisories.
- **Food Security and Macro Targets:** Despite the monsoon anomalies, the Centre has maintained a **Kharif foodgrain production target of 176 million tonnes**, backed by comfortable national buffer stocks of wheat and rice to insulate the domestic market from supply shocks.

Read more: [Managing the El Niño Threat](#)

Birth anniversary of Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay



Source: PIB

The Prime Minister of India paid homage to the great Indian novelist, poet, and journalist **Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay (1838-1894)** on the occasion of his birth anniversary on **27 th June** .

- **Early Life:** Born on **27 th June 1838** in the village of Naihati in the Bengal Presidency (present-day West Bengal).
 - One of the **first graduates** of the University of Calcutta and served as **Deputy Magistrate and Deputy Collector** from 1858.
- **The Bengal Renaissance:** He is widely regarded as the **Father of the Modern Bengali Novel** and a leading figure of the **Bengal Renaissance** .
- **Major Literary Contributions:**
 - **Anandamath (1882):** A landmark historical novel inspired by the **Sannyasi Rebellion** of the late 18th century.
 - It became a powerful source of nationalist inspiration, and its patriotic themes attracted restrictions under British rule.
 - **Vande Mataram:** Composed in the **1870s** in **Sanskritised Bengali** , it was first published in **Bangadarshan (1875)** and later incorporated into **Anandamath (1882)** .
 - **Vande Mataram** was sung at the 1896 session of the Congress by Rabindranath Tagore.
 - It became the rallying cry of the **Swadeshi Movement (1905)** , and the **first two stanzas** were adopted as the **National Song of India** by the **Constituent Assembly in 1950** .
 - In 2026, the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) has directed that **Vande Mataram must be played or sung before the National Anthem, Jana Gana Mana**, whenever both are part of an official event.
 - **Other Notable Works:** **Durgeshnandini (1865)** (first major modern Bengali romance novel), **Kapalkundala (1866)** , **Vishabriksha (1873)** , **Devi Chaudhurani (1884)** , and **Krishna Charitra** .
 - The first Indian English novel is widely considered to be **Rajmohan's Wife (1864)** by Bankim Chandra.
 - **Journalism:** Founded the monthly magazine **Bangadarshan (1872)** , which promoted **Bengali identity and nationalist literature** . It was later revived by **Rabindranath Tagore** .
- **Role in the Indian National Movement:** Through his writings, he promoted **cultural nationalism** , popularized the idea of **Bharat Mata** , and inspired **deshbhakti (patriotism)** as the highest duty.
- **Legacy:** He passed away on 8 th April 1894. For his immense contribution to literature and the nation's intellectual awakening, he is revered as **Sahitya Samrat (Emperor of Literature)**.



Read more: [150th Anniversary of India's National Song](#)